

The man who ignores age-40 burnout or refuses to change, Mayer says, soon “ignores his wife and screams at his children. He complains of boredom and fatigue, insisting his life has no meaning. He becomes increasingly detached, withdrawn, and introspective . . . High blood pressure develops and so do ulcers. Psychosomatic illnesses erupt: a man is suddenly beset by chronic fatigue, acute indigestion, mysterious backaches, painful joints, and migraine headaches. Every pain is a sign of cancer, every rapid heartbeat the precursor of a coronary.”

It's nothing, I suppose, that 30 mg. of Valium can't take care of. But living that way can get to be a drag.

You can avoid that kind of fate if you prepare to retire when the two-year test shows that it's time. I'm not suggesting you storm into the boss's office and quit. You still have productive work years in you. You still enjoy going to work, and the company still treats you well. But the two-year test shows that your *future* work life excites you about as much as a frontal lobotomy. That's when you should slowly, deliberately begin to move toward retirement. During the day, work hard on the job. But at night and on weekends, work on your retirement. Prepare your to-do list. Cut your living expenses to as close to \$50 a day as possible. Start bailing out of tax shelters and long-term financial commitments. And, most important:

Talk to others

to begin to identify with life after work.

TALK, TALK, TALK

Talk about retirement with those you trust. Their feedback gives you a new slant and helps you reexamine your decision. Talk with your shrink, if you're in therapy. At least you'll know you're not crazy. Talk to those business associates